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Interplay of Buddhist and Daoist Philosophies in Ming Dynasty China: A Cultural Analysis of

Journey to the West

Abstract

With an aim to explore the philosophy of Buddhism and Daoism as depicted through the two protagonists of *Journey to the West*, the goal of this research is to analyze their portrayal and significance within the context of this historical period, with the prevalence of these teachings during the Ming Dynasty from 1368 to 1644. During the Ming Dynasty, a renaissance in Chinese literature positioned novels as their famous literary media, with *Journey to the West* exemplifying this through its rich narrative interplay of Buddhist and Daoist philosophies. In this epic tale, Tripitaka embodies the Buddhist virtues of determination and compassion, guiding the quest for enlightenment, while Sun Wukong, with his Daoist spontaneity and rebellious spirit, illustrates how Buddhism and Daoism influenced people's views and behaviors during this era. The epic novel and Anthony C. Yu's Volume II revised edition of *Journey to the West* provide the contextual and narrative aspects of the characters. Michelle Zhang's "Hidden Theory of Mind in *Journey to the West*." was used to analyze how the philosophies of Buddhism and Daoism intertwine within the two characters. This research concludes that the journey and interactions between Tripitaka and Sun WuKung reflect the dynamic relationship between societal values, cultural beliefs, and philosophical views in Ming Dynasty China, offering insights into how Buddhist enlightenment and Daoist awakening intertwine in shaping the society's perception of

morality and immortality. Further research should explore the adaptation of *Journey to the West* in present-day literature, shedding light on its ongoing influence on modern interpretations of Buddhist and Daoist philosophy.

The iconic classic Chinese novel, *Journey to the West*, captivates and entices the readers with its spectrum of adventure, mythology, and more importantly, its profound philosophical insights. The epic had a religious and cultural influence during the Ming Dynasty, where the revival of Chinese values, literature, interest, art, and philosophy thrived during the late 1300s. With an aim to explore the philosophy of Buddhism and Daoism as depicted through the two protagonists of *Journey to the West*, the goal of this research is to analyze their portrayal and significance within the context of this historical period, with the prevalence of these teachings during the Ming Dynasty from 1368 to 1644. The gap explored between the Ming Dynasty and *Journey to the West* is twofold. The dynasty influenced the cultural, intellectual, and social environment in which the novel was written, while the novel played a significant role in cultivating the Ming Dynasty's literary landscape. The novel draws connections between Confucianism, Daoism, and Buddhism during this period. In *Journey to the West*, the two main protagonists embody and represent the two contrasting philosophical traditions of Daoism and Buddhism. Sun WuKung, the mischievous Monkey King reflects Daoist principles in his personal quest for freedom and immortality, while Tripitaka, the noble monk, has the notable ideals of Buddhism with compassion and quest for enlightenment. In *Journey to the West*, these character's behavior and interactions with the world around them provide insights into how Buddhism and Daoism shaped the Ming Dynasty's perception of morality and immortality.

The Ming Dynasty, spanning from 1368 to 1644, marked a period of cultural and economic prosperity, with political stability in China. The dynasty was founded by Zhu Yuan Zhang, who emerged victoriously from the collapse of the previous dynasty, the Yuan Dynasty, and established Nanjing as his capital (National Museum of Asian Arts). The era was characterized by its social hierarchy, moral values, and bureaucratic government such as having

an administrative system that was organized around the emperor who had absolute authority (National Museum of Asian Arts). Notable achievements such as the refurbishment of the Great Wall with the rise of a Ming banknote as their form of currency made the Ming Dynasty unique. Alongside cultural achievements of painting and textiles, the rise of novels became a famous literary media (National Museum of Asian Arts). It becomes evident that the era was marked by a rich synthesis of diverse philosophical and religious currents.

In China, Daoism is a religious tradition that encompasses a wide range of teachings emphasizing harmony with nature, spontaneity, and the cultivation of maintaining life force throughout the body, in other words, inner qi. Daoism is depicted as a “particularly receptive religion” that has shown adaptability throughout history (Wei 21). Known for its adaptability, Daoism historically embraced change. After setbacks in the pursuit of immortality potions, Daoism shifted its focus towards meditation and spiritual strengthening as a means to attain immortality instead (Wei 21). For example, The Quanzhen School, a Daoist School, aimed to integrate aspects of Confucianism and Buddhism into its teachings. Despite the differences in principles between Buddhism and Daoism, they remained tolerant towards Buddhism. While Buddhism focuses on attaining future nirvana, Daoism seeks paradise in the present. Central to Daoist philosophy is the concept of the Dao, or the Way, which represents the natural order of the universe. Daoism seeks to align themselves with the flow of the Dao, embracing simplicity, humility, and non-action (*wuwei*). Furthermore, Daoism advocates for self-cultivation through practices such as breath control, meditation, and alchemy, aiming to attain longevity, immortality, and spiritual transcendence. Daoism had a lot of influence in the Ming Dynasty as it was utilized in their daily life, shaping their cultural beliefs and practices. According to Wei Chiao, a scholar of Chinese religion, Daoist beliefs during this era specifically centered around the achievement

of immortality through various methods. One such method involved the transformation of both spirit and body, allowing individuals to transcend the boundaries of mortal life (Wei 19). This Daoist influence is evident in Ming Dynasty literature, where themes of nature, spontaneity, and transcendence were prominent.

Conversely, Buddhism is another major religious practice with a wide scope of teachings and principles that address aspects of human existence and spiritual development. Central to Buddhist philosophy are the Four Noble Truths. According to the Buddhist Scroll, *Abhidharma*, outlines the truth of suffering, the truth of the origin of suffering, the end of suffering, and the path that leads to the end of suffering. These philosophies are the foundational teachings that cultivate mindfulness and compassion in order to attain liberation from suffering (Eltschinger 254). Buddhist practices such as pilgrimage, compassion, and ethical conduct were integrated into various aspects of Ming's society. Due to Buddhist monasteries flourishing in the Ming dynasty, Buddhism served as the center of learning spiritual practices. *Sakyamuni*, the Buddha's name, meant "capability to be proper," and the temples dedicated to him in the name of goodness and humanity served to allow Buddhism to be understood in human terms (Chan 108). *Sakyamuni*, in particular, emphasizes virtuous actions and morality as a whole. The humanization of Buddhist deities, consisting of Avalokitesvara and Kuan-yin, displays this shift towards human-centered religious practices in China (Chan 108). This influence of Buddhism on Ming society laid the groundwork for the coexistence and interaction of other religious philosophies, particularly Daoism, which exerted considerable influence in the realm of spiritual beliefs and cultural practices.

In the novel, *Journey to the West*, the epic depicts a monk from the eastern regions of China embarking on a pilgrimage to the distant lands of India, tasked with the sacred duty of

retrieving the Scriptures of Buddha. With his band of companions including the mischievous Sun WuKung, the disciplined Sha Wujing, and the gluttonous Zhu Bajie, their journey is fraught with many predicaments and challenges. As the narrative unfolds, the reader is drawn into a world where the pursuit of personal freedom and the quest for spiritual awakening intertwine, inviting contemplation on the timeless themes of human nature, morality, and the search for meaning. (Wu Cheng'en 42-107).

Sun WuKung embodies the Daoist spirit with his rebellious nature, extraordinary power, and relentless pursuit of personal freedom. His ability to transform and defy authority reflects the Daoist emphasis on spontaneity and naturalness. In *Journey to the West*, the Monkey King's aspiration to attain the title "Equal to Heaven" reflects his desire for recognition and status within the celestial hierarchy. His defiance towards the deities and his audacious quest to challenge the heavenly order is driven by his ambition to transcend his earthly limitations and assert his own authority. It is shown in Chapter 8 when the two sages reported him to Tathagata saying, "The Jade Emperor threw down a decree of pacification and appointed him [Monkey King] a pi-ma-wen, but he despised the lowliness of that position and left in rebellion" (Cheng'en 50) underscoring his defiance towards authority. It exemplifies his rebellious nature and refusal to subservience, particularly when it comes from the Jade Emperor. This parallels the Daoist notion of striving for spiritual enlightenment and ultimate unity with the Tao. In Daoist philosophy, the heart, or mind, is believed to be equivalent to Heaven, sharing the same function and position within the human body as Heaven does within the universe (Liu 40). This concept suggests a profound connection between the individual's inner world and the cosmic order, emphasizing the importance of spiritual alignment and harmony with the universal Tao. Just as Daoism persists and thrives despite changing socio-political landscapes, the Monkey King

embodies resilience and adaptability as he overcomes challenges on his journey, showcasing the enduring nature of both Daoism and his character. This adaptability resonates with the Monkey King's character in *Journey to the West*, reflecting his ability to navigate and thrive in various situations through his cunning and resourcefulness. As Chan highlights, "Daoism in China underwent a profound transformation, shifting from a non-ego Indian religion to a humanistic one" (Chan 107) which illustrates the influence of Daoist principles in Ming Dynasty society. The novel's incorporation of Daoist philosophy into its narrative structure weaves together themes of spontaneity, transformation, and the pursuit of immortality, as it is shown in the Monkey King. Sun WuKung's interactions with other characters, including Tripitaka and various demons, serve as allegories for the Daoist quest for freedom and transcendence. Throughout the narrative, WuKung's journey mirrors the Daoist path of self-discovery and enlightenment, as he confronts obstacles and challenges with resourcefulness and resilience. In the first chapter of the novel, after the monkey king had decided to quest for immortality, his philosophy and ideals were evidently clear in the conversation he had with a boy that he met at the Great Western Ocean,

Are you a seeker of Tao?' 'I am indeed,' answered the Monkey King, my master at the house, the boy said, 'has just left his couch to give a lecture on the platform, however, he told me to go out and open the door, saying, 'There is someone outside who wants to practice austerities. You may go receive him.' It must be you, I suppose.' The Monkey King said, 'It is I, most assuredly!' 'Follow me then,' said the boy. (Cheng'en 40)

The conversation between the Monkey King and the boy at the Great Western Ocean in the first chapter of the novel serves as a poignant illustration of the Daoist themes embedded within the narrative. When asked if he is a seeker of Tao, the Monkey King responds affirmatively,

indicating his pursuit of the Daoist path of enlightenment and transcendence. This exchange highlights the Monkey King's philosophical inclination towards Daoist principles, setting the stage for his subsequent quest for immortality. As Sun Hongmei observes, "Sun WuKung transcends the traditional function of a trickster by challenging dualistic oppositions and embracing multiple possibilities," underscoring the Monkey King's representation of Daoist spontaneity and adaptability (Sun 90). His journey, characterized by a quest for personal freedom and immortality, reflects the Daoist pursuit of inner harmony and transcendence. As Ryor also states, "The Monkey King's journey is marked by his rebellious nature, extraordinary powers, and the quest for personal freedom," highlighting the alignment of WuKung's character traits with Daoist philosophy. In chapter 7, the actions of the Monkey King's rebellion became evidently clear as the two sages report his transgressions to Buddha complaining to them about the monkey's rebellion,

...he was given the temporary job of looking after the Garden of Immortal Peaches, where almost immediately he stole the peaches. He also went to the Jasper Pool and made off with the food and wine, devastating the Grand Festival. Half drunk, he went secretly into the Tushita Palace, stole the elixir of Lao Tzu...Immortal Master Erh-lang and his brothers fought and pursued him, even then he knew many tricks of transformation...

(Cheng'en 50)

Despite being entrusted with various responsibilities, the Monkey King's actions highlight his defiance of authority and his relentless pursuit of personal freedom. Through his rebellious nature and extraordinary powers, the Monkey King emerges as a powerful metaphor for the human quest for personal freedom and transcendence, echoing the timeless themes of Daoist philosophy.

In contrast, Tripitaka (also known as Xuanzhang) represents the stereotypical Buddhist monk as he is driven by an unwavering commitment to his spiritual quest. His portrayal reflects the noble virtues of compassion, determination, and self-discipline of Buddhist teachings. Despite Tripitaka's noble qualities and devotion to Buddhist principles, Bantly notes that "his adherence to the virtue of noninjury only succeeds in blinding him to the deeper nature of all forms" implying that Tripitaka's commitment to compassion might hinder him from effectively dealing with obstacles on his path to enlightenment, as his actions are solely driven by Buddhist philosophy (Bantly 514). For example, in chapter 14, where Tripitaka gets furious with the Monkey King for killing the six thieves who tried to rob and threaten them. He says, "This ape is so unruly, so obdurate! Despite my repeated pleadings, he still takes human life without cause" showing his detest towards killing even though he knew the dangers posed by the robbers (Yu 33). His decision to embark on his journey to the West knowing the full risk and dangers ahead of him, showed his determination and selflessness to retrieve the scrolls and spread dharma (Bantly 515). Despite his noble intentions and devotion to Buddhist principles, Tripitaka's strict adherence to nonviolence prevents him from fully comprehending the deeper essence or reality behind all forms of existence. However, In Chapter 12 of the novel when he makes his vow to retrieve the scriptures no matter what, saying, "I shall not spare myself in this journey, but I shall proceed with all diligence until I reach the Western Heaven. If I do not attain my goal, or these true scriptures, I shall not return to our land even if I have to die" (Cheng'en 64). Tripitaka acknowledges the numerous trials and temptations that he will face along the journey. He remained unwavering in his devotion to the Dharma, demonstrating the Buddhist ideal of overcoming obstacles on the path to spiritual awakening. Even before he began, he was given the highest regard of all the monks in the whole land. Ping-ei Mao, a Chinese author stated that:

Morally, he is the very embodiment of purity and devotion. He is totally perfect and completely successful. He commands unreserved respect. He is to begin his journey with a most distinguished background and the readers cannot help but look upon him with awe... (Pinge-I Mao 13)

Tripitaka's depiction as morally pure and devout highlights the Buddhist concept of moral integrity as a foundational aspect of spiritual attainment. In Buddhist philosophy, moral purity is essential for progress on the path to enlightenment, as it cultivates the necessary ethical foundation for spiritual growth. Tripitaka's unwavering commitment to his pilgrimage, despite the challenges and temptations he encounters along the way, exemplifies his adherence to moral principles and his dedication to the pursuit of spiritual truth. Additionally, Tripitaka's respect for Tathagata after receiving the scrolls in Chapter 98 of *Journey to the West* further emphasizes his deep admiration for the Buddhist teachings and the profound impact of his spiritual journey.:

Tripitaka led his three disciples to bow to Buddha, each pressing his palms together in front of him... Tripitaka kowtowed to thank him and to express his faith and obedience.

As before, he prostrated himself in homage three times to the Buddhist Patriarch with all earnestness and sincerity before he took the scriptures and left. (Cheng'en 93)

This passage from Cheng'en shows Tripitaka's deep reverence and devotion to Buddha, as depicted through his actions of bowing and kowtowing, exemplifying his embodiment of Buddhist principles in the novel. The act of bowing and pressing his palms together symbolizes Tripitaka's respect and humility towards Buddha, reflecting the Buddhist virtue of adoration for spiritual authority. Moreover, Tripitaka's earnestness and sincerity in prostrating himself three times before the Buddhist Patriarch underscore his unwavering faith and obedience to Buddhist teachings. By expressing gratitude and faith through these gestures, Tripitaka demonstrates his

commitment to the Buddhist path of enlightenment and his acknowledgment of Buddha's guidance in his spiritual journey. This portrayal highlights Tripitaka's adherence to Buddhist values and his role as a devout practitioner seeking spiritual enlightenment, contributing to the thematic exploration of Buddhism in the novel.

In the narrative of *Journey to the West*, Wu Cheng'en intertwines these contrasting characterizations, offering a rich exploration of philosophical themes inherent in both Daoism and Buddhism. Through the dynamic interplay between Sun WuKung and Tripitaka, the epic becomes a profound allegory of the human quest for spiritual enlightenment, blending elements of Daoist spontaneity with Buddhist discipline. It all begins with the introduction of the Monkey King's Daoist attributes, his rebellion against the Jade Emperor vividly portrayed in chapter 7 when he carelessly leaves a pool of monkey urine at the base of a pillar: "When he had finished writing, he retrieved his hair, and with a total lack of respect he left a bubbling pool of monkey urine at the base of the pillar" (Cheng'en 52). Tripitaka, on the other hand, is introduced as a true child of Buddha, embodying Buddhist virtues: "He's a true child of Buddha, it's no idle tale! Nor is it false that he is the Bodhi-matched." (Cheng'en 64). As the two characters embark on their journey together, they influence each other, with the Monkey King's inclination towards deception and violence countered by Tripitaka's adherence to Buddhist principles of compassion and non-violence. This dynamic is exemplified in Chapter 53, where the Monkey King deceives the True Immortal but ultimately chooses to spare his life:

I came up with the trick of enticing the tiger to leave the mountain and deceived you into fighting me. If old Monkey is willing to use his real abilities to fight you...I would beat you all to death. But to kill is not as good as to let live, and so I'm going to spare you and permit you to have a few more years. (Cheng'en 71)

As their pilgrimage concludes, both characters recognize the significance of their mutual dependence, culminating in their attainment of the sacred scrolls together in the West. Their acknowledgment of each other's contributions underscores the theme of collaboration and mutual support throughout their quest:

We two parties need not thank each other, for we are meant to support each other. We are indebted to our master [Tripitaka] for our liberation, through which we have found the gateway to the making of merit, and fortunately, we have achieved the right fruit. Our master also has to rely on our protection so that he may be firm in keeping both law and faith to find happy deliverance. (Cheng'en 86)

This complex interplay between Daoist spontaneity and Buddhist morality reflects the depth of the characters' evolving spiritual journeys in *Journey to the West*, from Sun WuKung's initial rebellion to Tripitaka's embodiment of compassion, culminating in their mutual recognition of the transformative power of cooperation and unity, as Wu Cheng'en masterfully illustrates the synthesis of these philosophical traditions within the narrative attaining enlightenment together.

The teachings of Buddhism and Daoism in the epic, *Journey to the West* serve as a rich tapestry of moral lessons and religious allegory by intertwining the two elements of these religious practices. Zhang interprets some of the readings of *Journey to the West* to unveil a tripart model of the mind that consists of an "empty mind state, mindful state, and a dualistic mind faculty." (Zhang 84). She provides an eye-opening theory that Tripitaka represents the "empty mind", a detachment from earthly desires, while the Monkey King embodies the "dualistic Xuan", a state of good and evil (Zhang 83). This explains the relationship between Buddhism and Daoism in *Journey to the West* and how they complement each other. The novel delves into the complexities of human nature through Sun WuKung, however, despite WuKung's Daoist

actions, the overarching narrative of the pilgrimage is deeply rooted in Buddhism, embodied by Tripitaka. Tripitaka's character, representing the "empty mind" state, serves as the foundation for enlightenment, and detachment from desires and distractions along the journey (Zhang 84). However, as Zhang highlights, just letting go of desires is not enough, as Tripitaka frequently falls short of sensory distractions and external influences from his other companions like Pigsy. This portrayal of Tripitaka's struggles echoes criticisms within the southern lineage of Buddhism, questioning the effectiveness of remaining detached and silent as a means to attain enlightenment (Zhang 85). In contrast, WuKung's character, representing the dualistic Xuan, lacks compassion and demonstrates a tendency for violence, highlighting the inherent conflicts between the two philosophies. The tension between Tripitaka's compassion and WuKung's aggression is depicted in Chapter 14, where WuKung's ruthless actions lead to Tripitaka's disappointment and anger towards him. Through the exposure of the strengths and weaknesses inherent in both the "empty mind" and the dualistic Xuan, the author of *Journey to the West* adopts a mixed view, acknowledging the interdependence and equal importance of both Daoism and Buddhism. The Monkey King's insight, stemming from his dualistic Xuan nature, enables him to discern between good and evil, aiding his companions along their journey (Zhang 85). Without him, Tripitaka would struggle to distinguish deceptive demons hindering his path to enlightenment. However, despite the Monkey King's Xuan nature and swift abilities to reach the West in a single somersault, Tripitaka guides him to gradually release desires, leading him and his companions on the slower path to the West, all aiming for enlightenment. They truly needed each other for their respective spiritual growth and journey.

With the prevalence of the novel in the Ming Dynasty, the pursuit of immortality was a prevalent theme in Chinese culture, particularly within Daoist teachings. Daoist practices aimed

at achieving longevity and immortality were prevalent, reflecting a broader societal fascination with transcending mortal limitations. *Journey to the West* captures this cultural fascination by portraying characters like Sun Wukong who seek immortality through various means, such as stealing the elixir of immortality and challenging celestial beings. These depictions resonate with the Ming Dynasty audience's interest in immortality and the supernatural. By weaving elements of immortality into its narrative, *Journey to the West* captures the imagination of Ming Dynasty readers, offering a fantastical exploration of human desires for longevity and transcendence beyond earthly confines. In addition to immortality, moral and ethical dilemmas are central to the characters' journeys in *Journey to the West*. Tripitaka's unwavering commitment to his pilgrimage despite facing numerous trials and temptations reflects the Buddhist emphasis on moral virtue and enlightenment. Conversely, Sun Wukong's rebellious nature and defiance of authority challenge conventional moral norms, yet his eventual alignment with Tripitaka's quest underscores the importance of moral transformation and redemption within Buddhist philosophy. Through its portrayal of moral struggles and ethical dilemmas, *Journey to the West* engages with Ming Dynasty audiences on profound questions of morality, duty, and personal virtue, resonating with Buddhist ideals while also challenging conventional notions of righteousness. Despite being rooted in the Ming Dynasty; the novel continues to have a lasting impact on Chinese culture and beyond. Its exploration of immortality and morality serves as a mirror of Ming Dynasty society, reflecting its aspirations and moral complexities. The novel's enduring legacy lies in its ability to offer timeless insights into the human condition and the quest for transcendence, resonating with audiences across generations and cultures.

Through numerous analyses of the epic, *Journey to the West*, this research unveils insights into the connection and reflection of Buddhism and Daoism through Tripitaka and Sun

WuKung. As the analysis delves into the depths of this literary masterpiece, it serves as a poignant reminder of the rich tapestry of religious and philosophical traditions that have profoundly influenced Chinese civilization. *Journey to the West* offers readers a transformative journey into the complexities of the human spirit and the relentless quest for enlightenment, weaving together themes of compassion, moral growth, and spiritual awakening. The enduring relevance of *Journey to the West* extends beyond its historical context, resonating with contemporary audiences across various mediums. Future research endeavors should explore the adaptation and reinterpretation of this timeless tale in present-day literature and popular culture. By examining how *Journey to the West* continues to inspire and inform modern interpretations of Buddhist and Daoist philosophy, scholars can shed light on its ongoing influence and relevance in shaping cultural narratives and values. In essence, the exploration of *Journey to the West* offers not only a deeper understanding of ancient Chinese literature but also a profound reflection on the universal themes of self-discovery, resilience, and the enduring pursuit of truth. As readers journey alongside Tripitaka and Sun WuKung, they are invited to contemplate their own spiritual paths and the timeless quest for enlightenment that transcends cultural boundaries and spans across generations.

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